

recorded that while in prison, Warbeck delivered to one of his supporters a book called “ABC”, also called a “Crosse Rowe”. Each letter in the book had a corresponding sign written by Warbeck. This was to ensure that using this cipher, the supporter could write back a message which would not be understood by those who didn’t know the code.

Diplomatic ciphers

Catherine of Aragon was believed to have learnt the art of cryptography and used to write in ciphers. This helped her play a vital role as a secret channel between King Ferdinand of Spain and King Henry VII of England. After King Henry VII’s death and her subsequent marriage to King Henry VIII, Catherine still didn’t relinquish her cipher to the ministers but handled the cipher for secret communication between the kings. In 1515, Catherine gave up her position as an ambassador when her worthy successor arrived from Spain.

Despite their advancements in other sectors, England remained largely hostile to the use of cryptography. Only near the end of Henry VII’s reign were ciphers used by the English court. However, ciphers were used by the Spanish ambassador, in the course of exploring diplomatic ties with England. While

the King of England chose to send his written plain text messages via sea, to protect their contents, King Ferdinand of Spain chose to communicate sensitive matters through ciphers with the help of Catherine.

Later on, ciphers were largely employed by English ambassadors to Spain to keep the government abreast of the situation in the host country. Ambassadors John Stile and Thomas Spinelly used ciphers to communicate with King Henry VIII.



King Charles 1628 AD